

**Addressing Homelessness Support System Fragmentation in Ontario
Final Progress Report**

Team C6

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2) Project Statement

2.1 Project Summary

Despite existing support services, homelessness is an issue that is only growing in Ontario and Canada (Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2024). Throughout the course of this project we as a team have identified that although there are connections between housing and homelessness, research and community, individuals experiencing homelessness face additional challenges related to accessing medical care, income assistance, access to mental health services, job-related information and referrals, transportation, and social support services, which can impact their capacity to secure, retain, and maintain stable housing (Gaetz et al., 2013). While there are numerous ongoing programs and services available to address the various needs of people experiencing homelessness, the homelessness continuum of services remains fragmented; which makes effective coordination among service providers and organizations challenging (Allin et al., 2024).

There is a major issue in how different parts of the system work together; and through our research we found that most of the services or programs exist in independent systems with their own agencies, funding sources, and delivery systems (Allin et al., 2024). Due to this independence, it is difficult for service providers to find opportunities to partner with other service providers to provide services, share data, use each other's resources, access funding, and respond to new issues in the community (Allin et al., 2024). The lack of coordination among these agencies creates inefficiency in the overall service delivery system and likely contributes to many people being unable to be served due to holes in the continuum of care.

To improve understanding of the existing challenges our group utilized a systems analysis which consisted of; a review of the current systems (literature review), an assessment of what is currently available to support community stakeholders (stakeholder engagement), a scan of current trends and developments (environmental scanning), and a transition gap analysis. The tools and organizations that currently exist, for example 211 Ontario, HIFIS, the Homeless Hub, CAEH and numerous other organizations were assessed. Although these tools have provided important services through means of service navigation, case management, funding awareness, research, and advocacy there was still an identified need to enhance collaboration among providers (Allin et al., 2024). Rather than adding new programs and services, the proposed solution is intended to enhance connections among those organizations already doing work in addressing Homelessness. The solution also supports service providers in identifying potential partners; sharing lessons learned, enhancing awareness of funding opportunities, highlighting gaps in services, and improving coordination across sectors.

To begin to develop an effective partnership model to promote inter-organizational partnerships the project recommends entering into strategic partnerships with organizations which provide services across the entire range of the homelessness continuum, partners like the Youth Services Bureau (YSB). The intent of the project is to have these organizations assist in testing the potential of the platform to enable collaborations among housing

providers, health care providers, social service agencies, education institutions, and all others within their communities.

It is anticipated that through the creation of a collaborative environment, system-wide coordination will be improved and the quality of collaboration among homelessness service providers will be enhanced (Allin et al., 2024). The proposed solution to reduce fragmentation and enhance communication between different organizations should result in an enhancement of the efficiency of existing supports and services, improvement of how resources are used, and ultimately better outcomes for those experiencing housing instability and the impacts of homelessness (Allin et al., 2024). Although the project has no intention of solving homelessness, it intends to help create a better-functioning systems barrier that may interfere with the delivery of services and supports currently available.

This project demonstrates that substantial improvements can be achieved by taking a collaborative approach and working with each other differently; therefore, it is feasible to enhance the way that communities utilize their existing resources to develop and support service systems that meet the differing needs of individuals who are homeless (Allin et al., 2024).

2.2 Defining the Systems Coordination Problem

Homelessness is typically seen as an exclusive housing issue, but according to the various forms of stakeholder involvement in this study, as well as research conducted, it's a much larger and more complex systems issue (Gaetz et al., 2013). Typically, people who experience homelessness have simultaneous interactions with numerous levels of support systems that include housing agencies, health care professionals, mental health support systems, financial assistance programs, job training programs, education, and/or other types of social service organizations (Gaetz et al., 2013; Allin et al., 2024). Many of these support systems do exist, and all of them can provide some form of assistance to those in need of their service. However, since each type of support system exists independently and has its own purpose, funding structure, reporting obligations, and eligibility criteria, there will be barriers to the individual receiving help and to the organization providing that assistance (Allin et al., 2024).

Fragmentation, one of the core themes in the project, refers to how organizations that are designed to provide interrelated services work separately from each other. The lack of coordination means that information, resources, and communication do not transfer smoothly across organizational boundaries. For example, the duplication in services often means individuals have to go through several different agencies and tell their story many times. They also have to complete the same intake process for each agency; and in addition, individuals will usually have to decide on their own which services they might be eligible for. From a larger systems viewpoint, it creates inefficiency, produces gaps in services, and limits the full potential of available support options (Allin et al., 2024).

This leads directly to another related issue referred to as service silos. Service silos happen when an organization's primary focus is its own program(s), responsibility(ies), or objective(s) who work independently. While some organizations are quite successful in their respective domains of expertise, there may exist little opportunity for a collaborative effort among organizations; sharing knowledge and learning, and making decisions together to name a few. Housing providers, health care organizations, social service agencies, community based organizations (CBOs), government programs, and others who provide services to homeless populations work independently of one another within their own systems. As a result, duplicate efforts are made by organizations providing similar services and obstacles to delivering comprehensive support are created (Allin et al., 2024).

These conditions have created larger barriers to coordinating efforts across the homeless-service system, and when organizations do not possess the necessary tools, processes, or networks to collaborate in a way that supports common goals, it creates coordination issues (Allin et al., 2024). Many service providers who participated in the stakeholder-engagement process indicate they had difficulty with navigating current resources, finding possible collaborative partners, being aware of available funding sources, and having knowledge of services provided by other agencies. Similar findings were identified from the environmental-scan conducted for this project. The project identified many programs and systems supporting service navigation, case-management,

funding-awareness, research, and advocacy, however, there were very few programs or systems providing ongoing operational-coordination among providers (Allin et al., 2024).

The "siloes" that are in place are an example of how fragmentation limits the potential for community-based solutions to address homelessness. In addition, the lack of relationship-building among organizations limits collaboration (Allin et al., 2024). In order to use what already exists there is a need to establish an environment that promotes collaboration amongst agencies, provide avenues for communication, develop standards for how information is provided through all agencies (quality/consistency) and foster collaboration within agencies. By establishing these elements, we will be able to discover methods in which to maximize our resources to help individuals achieve stable housing.

The findings from this analysis support the project's central hypothesis that a lack of coordination between existing supports represents a significant system barrier. Consequently, the proposed solution focuses on improving collaboration and information sharing among service providers rather than creating additional standalone services.

2.3 Understanding Fragmentation

The primary finding of this research is that homelessness in Ontario is most directly related to fragmentation as opposed to service insufficiency. The variety of organizations across the province providing different types of support such as housing, healthcare, mental health, financial assistance, job training and employment services, education services, outreach services, and community based support are all working together in an attempt to reduce homelessness (Gaetz et al., 2013). Despite the fact that a significant amount of funding has gone into developing programs and services to address homelessness, it still continues to be a very serious and complex social problem (Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2024). Therefore, while there are many organizations and services available to assist individuals experiencing homelessness, this does not appear to be enough to help address homelessness due to lack of coordination among organizations within the broader system (Allin et al., 2024).

Homelessness is becoming recognized in the literature as a systemic problem and therefore cannot be solved by one organization, sector, or intervention (Gaetz et al., 2013). As an example of this perspective, research conducted through Homeless Hub indicates that homelessness results from several interrelated social, economic, health and institutional factors which will require collaborative response strategies across many different sectors (Gaetz et al., 2013). In addition, it is stated by AMO that a collaborative effort will be required from various parties such as service providers, housing organizations, health care systems and community partners in order to effectively address homelessness (Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2024). National frameworks such as Reaching Home and coordinated access initiatives also clearly show the need for an integrated approach to improve communication, collaboration and collective actions among organizations (Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada, 2024). The research supports the idea that successfully exiting homelessness depend on both the existence of services and organizations' ability to work together towards common goals (Allin et al., 2024; Gaetz et al., 2013; Association of Municipalities of Ontario [AMO], 2024).

The term fragmentation is used to describe how separate systems create separate organizational functions that do not work together. Each organization has its own mandate, funding, reporting structure, priority, governance model and method of providing services. Although each organization will provide good service in terms of meeting its objectives, overall systemic fragmentation exists when there is little or no communication and data exchange. As a result, organizations may duplicate efforts, miss opportunities for partnership, compete for limited resources, operate with incomplete information, or struggle to coordinate responses to emerging community needs. These challenges are commonly referred to as service silos, where organizations focus primarily on their own operations with limited integration across the broader network of supports (Allin et al., 2024).

The evidence of fragmentation in this project is additionally supported by the results of the project's environmental scan. While there are many systems and organizations that are currently providing functions associated with information sharing, data collection, research, advocacy, awareness about available funding, creating policies for housing and homelessness,

and leading the non-profit housing sector; including but not limited to 211 Ontario, HIFIS, the Homeless Hub, the Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness, the Canadian Housing and Renewal Association, the Ontario Trillium Foundation, and the Ontario Non-Profit Housing Association; the results of the environmental scan and the gap analysis (Appendix B & C) indicated an insufficient infrastructure to support continued collaborations between providers, partnerships and collaborative learning, strategic planning and solving problems collectively. This indicates that although a number of services do exist, these services are generally organized to focus on particular areas or functions versus supporting those mechanisms that foster organizational relationship building and collaboration (Allin et al., 2024).

The literature and environmental scan confirmed many of the themes found through stakeholder engagement. Information sharing challenges, developing partnerships, community awareness of available resources, the fragmentation of funding models, as well as poor agency coordination were common descriptions from HICC, YSB, Better Street, Trek for Teens and many others during our consultation meetings, site visits, presentations, and discussions. Stakeholders also indicated that while there are organizations serving the same populations and having the same objectives, they do not have adequate opportunities to work together, share knowledge, or work collaboratively. The information gaps between agencies; duplicate effort; and lack of community awareness about what services, programs, and opportunities exist across the sector were frequent discussion points. These observations provide practical evidence that fragmentation is not merely a theoretical concept discussed in the literature but a challenge experienced by organizations working within the homelessness-support ecosystem (Allin et al., 2024).

These results were reinforced by the team's own analysis. The 5 Why Analysis (Appendix A), was used to identify the underlying reasons for fragmentation across housing, health care, social services, funding models, and organizational responsibilities contributing to systemic level issues. The Transition Gap Matrix (Appendix B) identified similar barriers at the transition points of organizations, sectors, and systems such as lack of communication, inconsistencies in collaborative practices, lack of access to shared information, and barriers to coordinating with multiple agencies. The source tracker (Appendix C), documented supporting evidence throughout Canada's homelessness literature, policy frameworks, and stakeholder feedback that demonstrated consistent themes of fragmentation, service siloing, and interagency coordination.

From a systems-thinking perspective, fragmentation is not simply a collection of disconnected organizations; it is a weakness in the relationships that connect those organizations. The effectiveness of a system is influenced not only by the performance of its individual components, but also by the quality of the interactions between them. When communication pathways, collaborative networks, and feedback mechanisms are weak, the overall capacity of the system weakens even when individual organizations are functioning effectively. As a result, meaningful improvements may be achieved not only through additional programs and services, but through stronger coordination, communication, and collaboration among existing providers (Stroh, 2015).

The common theme from the data collected in the literature review, environmental scan, and stakeholder engagement has clearly identified fragmentation as a primary challenge at the system level of Ontario's homelessness support community. Although existing agencies have provided many valuable resources such as service delivery, experience-based knowledge, access to funding sources, research and studies, advocacy efforts and leadership in addressing homelessness issues, there are still opportunities to improve agency inter-connection (Allin et al., 2024). A collaborative approach to understanding fragmentation is foundational to the proposed solution: a collaboration and coordination platform that will be focused on strengthening relationships among providers, improving communication and reducing barriers to accessing information and services throughout the homelessness sector.

2.4 Stakeholders, Boundaries, and SDGs

Project Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Direct/Indirect
Service Providers in the Homelessness Support Sector	Direct - Primary Stakeholder - End User of Project
Front line workers working with individuals experiencing homelessness	Direct - Primary Stakeholder - End User of Project
Individuals experiencing or at risk of homelessness	Indirect - Secondary Stakeholder - Long-term beneficiary of project implementation and use
Municipal, provincial, and federal governments	Indirect - Secondary Stakeholder - Potential funder of platform, Recipient of community data insights
Web Developers	Direct - Supporting Stakeholder - Responsible for developing website front and backend.
Platform Administrators	Direct - Supporting Stakeholder - Responsible for maintaining website and databases, monitoring forum posts, regular testing.

Boundaries of Project

What We Are Not Doing
Developing a solution that will directly benefit individuals experiencing or at risk of homelessness.

Boundaries				
Timeline	Budget	Deliverable	Stakeholders	Resources
2 weeks for design process steps: *Empathize *Define *Ideate *Prototype *Test *Iterate	\$750+ stipend available	MVP, Prototype of website (limited functionality) that visually shows the possibilities and features of website Focus on frontend development and user interface design	Focus on designing for primary stakeholders: *Service Providers in the Homelessness Support Sector *Front line workers working with individuals experiencing homelessness	*Some coding skills *Laptops with coding software *UX design experience *Partner feedback (when available)

Applicable Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

SDG	Direct/Indirect Impact
1 - No Poverty	Indirect Positive
10 - Reduced Inequalities	Indirect Positive
11 - Sustainable Cities and Communities	Indirect Positive
16 - Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions	Direct Positive
17 - Partnership for the Goals	Direct Positive

3) Project Justification

3.1 Defining the Root Cause

The results of the 5 Why Analysis (Appendix A), completed during this project, were used to look past the surface symptoms of homelessness and reveal the root level system challenges that are contributing to the homelessness issue. Homelessness is typically viewed as an issue of available or affordable housing (Gaetz et al., 2013). However, repeated evaluation of the challenge has resulted in identifying larger challenges of coordination, communication, and inter-organization collaboration. The analysis showed that there are numerous services, programs, and resources that currently exist within the homeless support system. The problem is these resources usually function in a fragmented system with little opportunity for the resources to work together effectively (Allin et al., 2024). As organizations continue to specialize and provide separate services, under different funding structures, mandates and reporting requirements, opportunities for coordination and communication are likely to be reduced (Allin et al., 2024). The project found that a lack of organization fragmentation and poor inter-provider collaboration is one of the most significant root causes that have contributed to the systemic issues. Therefore, it is consistent with the goal of this project to improve the inter-organizational collaboration, communication and coordination among organizations by focusing on those items instead of developing new independent service models.

3.2 Community Partner Findings

Throughout the project, we worked with many different types of organizations and individuals involved in the homelessness support system. Organizations that were consulted include Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada (HICC), Youth Services Bureau (YSB), BetterStreet, Trek for Teens, community partners, and fellow C4 participants. Through these engagements we presented to various stakeholders, conducted visits, held meetings with our partners and stakeholders, had open-ended feedback sessions during our project work and discussed the prototype on Demo Day. These engagements helped us understand the reality of organizations that are part of the homeless sector and allowed us to link literature-based findings to "real life" experiences.

A common theme that has been found across almost all of the engagement with stakeholders is the difficulty of collaboration and coordination among the organizations. Stakeholders were aware of the numerous value-added programs and services within their respective sectors; however, most felt that it was difficult for them to communicate with one another, share information, and be made aware of available resources across these same sectors. Many stakeholders reported that while organizations are working toward the same goal(s), there are limited opportunities for them to collaborate, create partnerships, or engage in coordinated efforts. The above findings have further validated the projects' conclusion that fragmentation is due to the absence of mechanisms to link existing organizations and resources together, rather than an insufficiency of service offerings (Allin et al., 2024).

Another frequent concern cited by all stakeholder groups were information and communication gaps; specifically they had difficulty keeping current on new programs, funding sources, organizational initiatives, and what services are being offered by other agencies providing service in the community. Information gaps were a topic mentioned repeatedly throughout this research because the rapidly evolving nature of how service is delivered has created an environment where participants have great difficulty maintaining knowledge about what is currently being offered. Participants stated that while there are many organizations, websites, networks and communication vehicles offering information, identifying potential collaborative opportunity and/or resource sharing is a challenge due to the dispersal of information among them. Findings from this research are consistent with findings from the projects' environmental scan, which indicated that there are numerous valuable resources currently operating independent of one another within the homeless support ecosystem (Allin et al., 2024).

Funding and organization capacity were a few of key areas that was brought up in the discussions with the stakeholders. A number of the partners discussed the barriers in terms of getting funding, meeting reporting requirements, having limited staff capacity, and prioritizing operational needs. Organizations are generally motivated to collaborate; however, several of the stakeholders said they have competing commitments and resources that will prevent them from building relationships and coordinating across sectors. This information is an example of how important it is to create easy-to-use and efficient methods for collaborative efforts that do not add on more administrative work.

One of the biggest results of engaging with stakeholders is a perceived need to have better ways to share ideas, successes, etc., among organizations. A common theme throughout the discussions were the benefits of each organization being able to learn from others, see how other organizations have successfully addressed similar issues, identify possible partnership opportunities, and reduce the duplication of efforts. As stated above, many times, multiple organizations will be dealing with the same issue yet do so independently because there are very few (if any) structured methods for these organizations to communicate or work together (Allin et al., 2024). This finding suggests that improving information sharing and collective learning may strengthen the overall effectiveness of the homelessness-support ecosystem.

Importantly, stakeholder engagement also impacted how the project developed. The early conversations about the project discussed solutions for better access to service and support. As the consultation continued, however, feedback indicated that many of the issues were centered in communication, coordination, partnerships and information exchange among organizations. In fact, stakeholders repeatedly emphasized the need to develop relationships with each other in the field versus developing new independent services. As a result, the project evolved toward a provider-focused collaboration and coordination platform designed to address the underlying systems challenges identified throughout the engagement process.

Although stakeholders represented different organizations, sectors, and perspectives, a common message emerged across consultations, site visits, presentations, and feedback

sessions: organizations require stronger mechanisms for collaboration, communication, and coordination. These findings validated the conclusions reached through the literature review, environmental scan, and project 5-Why analysis while providing practical insight into how fragmentation is experienced within the sector. Most importantly, stakeholder feedback helped ensure that the proposed solution responds to challenges identified by organizations themselves and reflects the realities of those working directly within the homelessness-support ecosystem.

3.3 Key Findings Summary

The results from the literature review, stakeholder engagement activities, environmental scan, and project analysis showed that there were repeated themes about fragmentation within the homelessness support system. This is consistent with the 5 Why Analysis (Appendix A), Transition Gap Matrix (Appendix B), and Source Tracker (Appendix C) provided.

Key Finding	Evidence Source	Significance
Fragmentation exists across the homelessness-support ecosystem.	Literature review, stakeholder engagement, environmental scan.	Indicates that organizations often operate independently despite addressing interconnected issues.
Fragmentation was identified as a root cause of system challenges.	5 Why Analysis (Appendix A).	Demonstrates that coordination challenges stem from underlying system structures rather than a lack of services.
Service silos limit collaboration and information sharing.	HICC, YSB, BetterStreet, Trek for Teens consultations.	Reduces opportunities for partnership development, collective planning, and coordinated responses.
Numerous services, resources, and supports already exist.	Environmental Scan and Source Tracker.	Suggests the primary challenge is not a lack of services but a lack of coordination between them.
Collaboration infrastructure is limited.	Transition Gap Matrix and stakeholder feedback.	Highlights a gap in provider-to-provider communication, knowledge sharing, and partnership development.
Stakeholders support stronger coordination mechanisms.	Site visits, consultations, presentations, and Demo Day feedback.	Validates the need for solutions that strengthen collaboration across organizations.

Improved coordination may strengthen existing systems.	Literature review, stakeholder engagement, and project analysis.	Supports a systems-based approach focused on improving relationships between organizations rather than creating additional services.
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The results show that homeless support systems in Ontario have well-functioning individual organizations working together in a fractured community. Although each service has its own value, and each has their own funding opportunity, research resource, or advocacy initiative, all stakeholders mentioned that they faced problems concerning communication, collaboration, information exchange, and developing partnerships. The results indicate that the systems do not need to be improved but need better coordination among existing providers (Allin et al., 2024). The results will also help guide the design of the suggested provider focused collaboration and coordination platform as explained below.

3.4: Research to Design Matrix

The Research to Design Matrix connects our research directly to how we built PartnerPath, turning system problems into easy-to-use digital tools for workers. To fix the major issue of organizations working in isolated silos, we built a Centralized Service Provider Directory so frontline staff can easily see other services across different regions. We also included Dynamic Organization Profiles that show real-time info like open beds, language options, and rules for signing up, which stops clients from being sent to the wrong places. To make partnering up simpler for busy staff, our Automated Partnership Matching feature uses basic profile details to actively suggest smart ways for different groups to work together on joint projects. We added a secure Discussion Forum just for verified workers so they can share tips, ask for advice, and swap grant templates without any pressure from funders or policymakers. Finally, to keep sensitive workflows safe and private, organizations must register and be verified before they can see or use the platform. This onboarding wall keeps out fake accounts and creates a high-trust, safe space where groups can finally collaborate to close gaps in care.

4) Project Design Thinking

4.1 SOUnD Thinking Framework

Sustainable

We look for this project to have a long-term, beneficial impact. By aligning the project with some of the sustainable development goals laid out by the United Nations, we hope this project contributes to a better, more sustainable society for all. As our focus was more on social sustainability, our vision for the outcomes of our project is mainly reduced inequalities (SDG 10) and partnership for the goals (SDG 17). With stronger networks of social services, improved and increased impact can be made on the lives of individuals facing homelessness. They will face fewer instances of being sent from place to place trying to acquire what they need, as service providers would be knowledgeable, and filling in service gaps through coordinated efforts, greater capacities, and reduced duplication. While we imagine this project starting at a smaller scale, it could become much greater and showcase how different sectors could work together and coordinate in search of attaining the sustainable development goals, as all sectors are needed for solving the “wicked” problems existing across the world and in our own communities.

In terms of life cycle analysis, the biggest points of concern would be around hosting the platform and data server emissions. We did not take these into account during our design process due to the limited timeframe and uncertainty of project implementation.

Economic sustainability was not fully considered, again, due to the short timeframe and lack of expertise within our team regarding web platform development, rollout, and maintenance. We did consider possible shortfalls, such as insufficient interest or onboarding to garner support from potential funders for development. We do hope that this project allows for existing funding opportunities (for service providers) to bring about more impact and benefit through coordinated efforts and shared expertise. The increased visibility of funding opportunities on the funding portal will also aim to improve access to funding for smaller organizations to help them develop projects and grow their presence.

Out-of-the-Box

Our project, while it has similarities to existing social media platforms that both individuals and organizations use, such as LinkedIn, has a specific objective and features tailored to the end users of the platform, service providers and frontline workers. It is a social network for good. Our solution 1 which we ideated was completely inside the box to the point that we found another platform that was already delivering almost exactly what we had imagined.

Our provider collaboration hub, while it does achieve some aspects of pre-existing collaborative organizations and platforms such as HomelessHub, ONPHA Funding Tracker, and CHRA (See Appendix B), the innovation of our project lies in the coordination of all of these resources in one place. We’ve designed specifically for service providers, a space they can connect, ask questions, share resources, without having to uphold a certain appearance.

One of our partners highlighted this as a positive of our design. He explained that when, for example, funders are “in the room”, service providers would not, say, share on the discussion forum that they are struggling with an issue and are looking for guidance. Funders would want to know that the organizations they are supporting are secure, that their transaction is risk-free. In other spaces, outside PartnerPath, there would not be this freedom.

Our project is also special in its tailored recommendations based on the signed up organization’s mission, their declaration of what they do, who they serve, where they are, etc. This reduces the burden of having to seek out opportunities that your organization is eligible for across many sites and navigators. This is especially helpful for individuals new to working in these fields, or those who have had to take on extra roles due to lack of resources.

Universal

Our project is not universal in the sense that everyone can use it. It is tailored specifically to be used by service providers and frontline workers. However, we have designed the interface to be user-friendly, following UX design principles: User-centricity, Consistency, Hierarchy, Context, User control, Accessibility, Usability (Stevens, 2026).

UX Design Principle	Presence in Platform Design
User-centricity	Everything is tailored for the end user and allows them to explore what they’d like. With the end goal of making connections with other organizations, our landing page presents the main option ‘Find Your Next Partner’ which directs the user to the Service Provider Directory.
Consistency	Same fonts, button styles, colours, container styles, headings, subheadings, and body text styles and sizes, and content placement is consistent across all pages. Ex: If the user sees something that looks like a button or that it is clickable, it will be (light blue buttons/blue outline on clickable components).
Hierarchy	Use of hierarchy in font sizes and colours to depict what is most important and what should be read first. Coloured bars with white text are titles/categories, page headings are bold and large font. Action points (buttons and clickable components) are made more visible through colour and contrast (ex: borders on containers/”cards” that are clickable).
Context	We expect users to be on a laptop or computer accessing the platform, but we could design mobile/tablet breakpoints in the future. We do not expect them to be using this platform in the presence of clients they are supporting, nor in the presence of potential funders, or policymakers. It is their own support network

	that they can access.
User control	All action points (‘Connect’, visiting external sites of organizations, posting on the discussion forum) are all up to the choice of the user. There is no harm in taking these actions, and choices such as ‘connect’ing or posting could be undone.
Accessibility	The platform consists of simple language, WCAG cross-checked colour contrast ratios for buttons and coloured bars. It has a straightforward layout on all pages with clear typography and readable font sizes. If this project were to be fully developed, it would follow WCAG 2.1/2.2 to fulfill legal requirements.
Usability	Our platform is low-complexity and does not overload the user with information. It is easy to navigate using the nav bar and the user would be able to access the different pages from multiple points. In the future, if new developments or additions would be incorporated into the platform, we would ensure they are consistent with what is already on the platform and be of the same straightforward, easy-to-understand nature and design.

Figure 1

User Experience Principles presentation prepared by Olivia

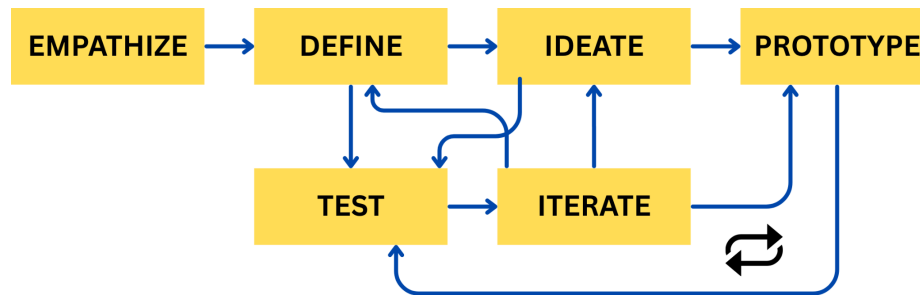
Important Principles to Consider

User-Centered Design - Design around the needs of your target users, not your assumptions. - Identify: - Who is using it? - What are they trying to accomplish? - What barriers might they face?	Simplicity - Keep screens uncluttered. - Show only information needed for the current task. - Avoid unnecessary features or steps.	Clear Information Architecture - Organize content logically. - Group related items together. - Make navigation intuitive.
Consistency - Similar elements should behave similarly. - Use consistent: - Navigation - Labels - Buttons - Layouts	Visibility of Important Actions - Primary actions should stand out. - Users should immediately know: - What they can do - What they should do next	Accessibility - Consider accessibility from the beginning: - Sufficient text size - Colour contrast - Clear labels - Keyboard navigation (if applicable) - Simple language - Avoid relying solely on colour
User Flow Efficiency - Map the path from start to finish. - Ask: - How many clicks does it take? - Are there unnecessary steps? - Can tasks be completed quickly?	Feedback - Users should know what's happening. - Examples: - Confirmation messages - Progress indicators - Success/error states	Error Prevention - Try to prevent mistakes before they happen. - Examples: - Clear instructions - Logical form fields
Recognition Over Recall - Users shouldn't have to remember information from previous screens. - Keep important information visible. - Use menus, labels, and prompts.	Trust and Transparency - Users should understand: - What information is being collected - Why it is needed - Who can see it	Inclusivity - Assume varying levels of digital literacy. - Minimize typing where possible. - Use plain language. - Support multiple pathways to the same information. - Consider users accessing the platform on older phones or with limited internet.

The principles in Figure 1 (above) helped guide the design of our platform mockup to ensure an intuitive, user-friendly experience.

Design

Figure 2
Design Process Diagram



Note. Visual representation of design process, testing and iterating at every step.

Our project, while not explicitly, followed the design process of:

EMPATHIZE - DEFINE - IDEATE - PROTOTYPE - TEST - ITERATE

We used a user-centred design approach to recognize, understand, and address the issues that affect our partners that serve in organizations supporting individuals facing homelessness.

EMPATHIZE PHASE: In this phase, we heard from different project partners about what they and the individuals they serve experience daily. We also heard from partners such as HICC about legal complexities within the homelessness support systems. We took notes while remaining attentive and respectful, especially during site visits. See Appendix G.

DEFINE: In this phase, we looked at the problem of homelessness from a systematic lens. We gathered research that reflected what our community partners had highlighted. Between our site visit and meeting notes with partners and research gathered and assessed, we began our steps in defining the problem using the 5 Whys method (Appendix A). We identified fragmentation across service providers in the homelessness support network.

TEST: At each step of the design process, starting with DEFINE, we tested the outputs of each phase with our community partners. We had a chance to present what we identified as the problem from a systems approach. All partners affirmed that this fragmentation is a significant issue that affects how providers serve their clients. No iteration was needed in our problem definition.

IDEATE: In this phase, we looked to address the problem we identified in two different ways. Solution 1 looked at reducing barriers to accessing services provided by organizations by centralizing access for individuals experiencing or at risk of homelessness. The vision was to have users input their needs and a few demographics to help refine results, then return programs/organizations that could support them in their needs, were close to them geographically, and served people that fit their demographics. Solution 2 looked to connect service providers working in the homelessness sector and facilitate collaboration between

them. It would be an online hub that allowed these provider organizations to find out who's working in what field and who they could collaborate with on projects/applications/etc.

TEST: We presented both solution ideas to some of our community partners. Both were well received, with concerns about data privacy and collection with solution 1. See Appendix H.

ITERATE: After receiving this feedback on solution 1, our team sought out relevant policies and frameworks surrounding data collection and privacy related to demographic data. We used this research to inform how we would design the intake questionnaire - and we planned to make it not personal, so as to not conflict with or fall under the Ontario Human Rights Code.

PROTOTYPE: In this phase, we moved forward with solution 1 with our updated knowledge and design plan. We created a demo that allowed for users to fill in the criteria of what services they need, and it would return all relevant provider organizations and their information for contact/applying.

TEST: We presented our prototype to two partners (HICC, Trek for Teens) who brought more concerns around data collection, as well as overlap with an existing service, 211.ca.

ITERATE: We decided that there was no benefit in continuing developing solution 1 due to its high similarity with 211.ca. There was no further iteration on this solution.

PROTOTYPE: We did not return to IDEATE after this shift in direction, but we returned to solution 2, the provider collaboration hub. We developed a prototype - a coded website that showcased the potential functionality of the site.

TEST: We presented our prototype to more partners that initiated a discussion on the potential benefits of our solution. Feedback was positive, but we had included the initial solution 1 in this platform, which was determined to be out of the scope of the project, given our focus problem and end users.

ITERATE: We removed the page designed to support clients, and focused only on developing features that would support service providers. We also developed mockups of a potential interface for the platform that was more user-friendly and navigable.

PROTOTYPE: We fully developed two parts of our solution, a semi-functioning coded prototype, and a non-responsive mockup of each page of the platform.

TEST: We presented both working pieces of our solution on demo day, to gain feedback on both. Partners and community members enjoyed and appreciated the concept and saw great value in it. They also gave feedback about potential future features that may not be feasible to implement before the end of the project.

ITERATE: We intend to pursue the development of the mockup website due its increased usability, accessibility, and consistency with PartnerPath branding materials. Future features will not be implemented, but captured in our report for handoff.

4.2 Design Constraints

Our team designed PartnerPath while considering several real-world constraints. Privacy is a key concern, so we intentionally avoided storing any client data and limited the platform to organization-level information to reduce risk, and because the service providers would be opting into the service they would decide which information they would be comfortable sharing from their organization—the data would not only be private but there is obligation to share data the services providers believe should be kept quiet. Governance is also a challenge, as it is unclear which organization or authority would be responsible for maintaining, verifying, and moderating the platform’s content and this is a problem that would likely need to be addressed in our project’s future. Participation depends on organizations actively contributing and keeping their information up to date, which may be difficult without strong incentives or accountability but likely we could encourage participation by having partners who join to promote our service; a good word of mouth would be essential. From a technological standpoint, our current prototype is limited, as it is a static, browser-based system using local storage, meaning data is not shared across users or scalable in its current form. Finally, funding is a major constraint, since developing and maintaining a fully functional, secure, and widely adopted platform would require long-term financial support, staffing, and infrastructure.

4.3 Alternative Solutions Considered

Our team considered two main solutions to address gaps in the homelessness support system. The first solution our team came up with was a Community Support Navigation and Coordination Model that focused on helping individuals directly by creating a centralized tool to find and access services more easily, reducing confusion caused by fragmented information. However, we recognized that while this improves accessibility, it does not fully address the root issue of poor coordination between service providers as it exists to solely service those in homelessness, which is helpful but not the reason why care is fragmented. Thus, our team leaned towards developing. Solution Two which was a Community Partnership Navigation Model, that focused solely on aiding service providers by creating a platform for organizations that encouraged communication, collaboration, and awareness across service providers who currently operate in silos. We selected this solution because our research showed that system fragmentation is largely driven by a lack of coordination between organizations, not just lack of access for individuals. By strengthening connections between providers, our platform can indirectly improve client outcomes as increased communication between services providers and resources would make the care they provide more effective and efficient. The hub would also reduce duplication of services and create a more efficient and integrated support network.

4.4 Convergence Process

Our team arrived at the final solution through an iterative convergence process by narrowing broader ideas based on research insights and feedback. Initially, we explored multiple directions, including a solution focused on helping individuals directly navigate services. However, we recognized that platforms like 211 Ontario already address this need to some extent, making our first solution less impactful as we would merely be duplicating an existing service over creating a solution that could begin to address the issue of fragmentation. Through our 5 Why Analysis and Transition Gap Matrix, we identified that the deeper issue lies in the lack of coordination and communication between service providers. Feedback also indicated that our earlier ideas were too broad, prompting us to refine our focus. As a result, our team shifted toward the Community Partnership Navigation Model, targeting organizations instead of individuals. This led us to design a centralized digital platform that improves collaboration, visibility, and information sharing across providers, making it a more focused and effective solution.

4.5 Validation and Refinement

Throughout the project, we received feedback that helped refine our solution and make it more realistic. Partners emphasized the importance of accessibility, including language options, cultural considerations, and maintaining a user-friendly, uncluttered interface. They also provided input on system features such as connecting similar services, showing nearby resources, and addressing intake forms, account setup, and profile management. Concerns about privacy and safety, including risks like fake accounts and sensitive issues such as human trafficking, highlighted the need for strong security measures. We also considered challenges around organizational buy-in, authority levels, and who would manage and maintain the platform. Additionally, funding was identified as a key factor, as organizations often compete for limited resources, which can affect collaboration, so our solution is designed as a prototype that demonstrates potential while acknowledging these real-world constraints.

4.5 Testing and Validation

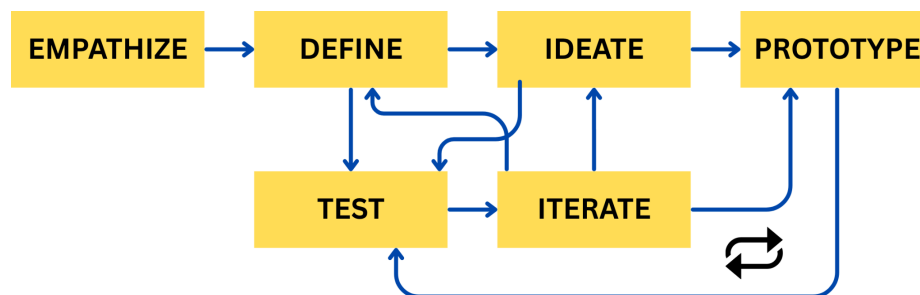
Our primary method of testing/validation of our solution(s) was through partner feedback. In our midway presentation, we shared our two solutions we ideated to address the systematic problem of fragmentation across social service providers that we identified through research and partner discussions. Our feedback consisted of positive remarks towards both solutions, but more than one partner highlighted concerns with solution 1 - the central access point for individuals. The main concerns were around data collection and privacy, as well as concerns about the expected use of a digital platform amongst individuals facing homelessness. Solution 2 garnered positive feedback and reflections on how it could benefit service providers working in the field with specific examples, such as more coordination for services and less duplication. It was also encouraged to be a project that could expand provincially.

As we started our first sprint, we definitely blurred the line between our two solutions. We did not clearly decide which solution we would pursue, and ended up beginning to develop solution 1 despite its critiques.

To evaluate our direction of development, we met with partners who gave us critical feedback that shifted our direction entirely. A partner from HICC highlighted that 211.ca was a solution very similar to ours and questioned our added value. After looking into this resource, we went back many steps and re-evaluated what our partners and research showed were really the fundamental issues in delivering support. We shifted our focus and drew distinct lines around solution 2, a provider collaboration hub. It would only be for the direct benefit of service providers working in the homelessness support sector.

As we began working on solution 2, we had another opportunity to get feedback on our direction, and it was received much better, with support from multiple partners. Our partners brought questions and suggestions to help us refine our solution and implementation plan. They affirmed the direction we were heading in was one that could bring benefit and address a problem not only identified in literature, but experienced daily by service providers.

Figure 2
Design Process Diagram



Note. Visual representation of design process, testing and iterating at every step.

5) The Project Itself

Link to project demo: <https://partnerpath.onrender.com/>
(GitHub Repository - See Appendix I)

5.1 Overview of Community Support Coordination Portal

Based on the proposed solution we came up with we designed a coordination portal/site designed solely for social service providers to act as a resource directory and connect with each other (Appendix E). This was developed to allow for collaboration between social service providers as their information is currently kept separate from other service providers and they are encouraged to manage their information in isolated ways; this coordination hub acts as a bridge over the gap caused by silos. There are some organizations that fall through the cracks and as a result might not have enough exposure or are missing collaborations that could aid in the homelessness effort. The site provides a simple sign-on feature, and provides users with access to the site's database of social service providers, such as health, housing, and other such providers. For new social service providers looking to join this service, there is a simple intake form that takes down information that could be useful, such as funding received, and other such features.

5.2 Platform Architecture

The system would ideally consist of a full stack, but currently uses mock files to mimic a database due to the time-sensitive efforts of the course. The information flow consists of a database of existing service providers, an intake form that adds to this database as new service providers sign up, as well as a database for authentication. There is also a forum page that lets service providers communicate with each other. The platform coordination model is a three-way handshake between the platform, and service providers that sign-up on it, with an additional use-case of providing information on the organization's current status such as available beds. The platform provides the space for service providers to communicate and collaborate with each other, which can help uplift grassroots organizations and ensure a more robust network of social services that can also help with funding.

5.3 Organization Registration and Onboarding

Organizations enter the website. They click the sign-in/register button in the top left of the home page. This lets them create an account and register for the site's services, such as forum use. Then there is also an intake form for onboarding; this allows for organizations to list themselves to increase visibility, provide information on their work, statistics and funding, and other such details such as available beds. After signup the organization is added to the database and labels are generated and assigned to that organization to allow for easier searching.

5.4 Resource-Sharing and Collaboration Features

PartnerPath includes a Resource Sharing Hub that allows homelessness service providers to exchange information, resources, and knowledge in one centralized location. Organizations can create detailed profiles that outline their services, areas of expertise, populations served, and current initiatives. This makes it easier for providers to understand what supports are available across the sector and identify organizations that may be helpful partners. The platform also includes discussion forums where organizations can ask questions, share experiences, discuss challenges, and exchange best practices. In addition, providers can share useful materials such as referral forms, program information, funding resources, reports, and community updates.

These features help address one of the key problems identified through our research: the lack of communication and awareness between service providers. Many organizations operate independently and may not know what services are available within their community or region. By creating a space for information sharing and collaboration, PartnerPath reduces information gaps and encourages organizations to learn from one another. This can lead to better decision-making, stronger relationships between providers, and more effective support for individuals experiencing or at risk of homelessness.

5.5 Referral Pathways and Collaboration Workflows

The Referral Network feature helps organizations identify service providers that offer supports their clients may need. Through detailed organization profiles and searchable service categories, providers can quickly locate relevant organizations and learn about the services they offer. This allows organizations to make referrals more efficiently and connect individuals with supports that match their specific needs. Instead of relying on informal networks or limited knowledge of available services, organizations can use the platform to find accurate and up-to-date information about potential referral partners.

The platform also supports collaboration workflows by encouraging communication between organizations before, during, and after referrals are made. Through discussion forums and professional networking opportunities, providers can establish connections and build working relationships with other organizations. This helps create a more coordinated approach to service delivery and reduces the likelihood that individuals will fall through gaps in the system. By improving awareness and communication between providers, the Referral Network helps create smoother pathways to support and contributes to a more connected homelessness support system.

5.6 Partnership Development and Collaboration Opportunities

One of the primary goals of PartnerPath is to support partnership development across the homelessness sector. Many organizations provide valuable services but may have limited opportunities to connect with others working toward similar goals. Through organization profiles and networking features, providers can discover organizations with complementary

services, shared objectives, or expertise in specific areas. This allows organizations to identify potential partners that they may not have otherwise encountered.

These partnerships can lead to a variety of collaboration opportunities, including joint projects, shared resources, coordinated service delivery, and collaborative funding applications. By bringing organizations together, PartnerPath encourages providers to work collectively rather than independently when addressing complex social challenges. Strong partnerships can also reduce duplication of services and improve the overall efficiency of the support system. As organizations build stronger connections and share their knowledge and resources, they become better equipped to respond to community needs and support individuals experiencing homelessness.

5.7 Service Gap Reporting and Needs Assessment Features

PartnerPath includes a Service Gap Identification Tool that allows organizations to identify and discuss unmet needs within their communities. Through forum discussions and feedback from service providers, organizations can report barriers to accessing services, populations that may be underserved, and areas where additional supports are needed. Since providers work directly with individuals experiencing homelessness, they are often in a strong position to recognize emerging issues and service gaps before they become larger problems.

Collecting information from multiple organizations helps create a broader understanding of challenges across the homelessness sector. This information can be used to support needs assessments and identify priorities for future services, programs, and community initiatives. By highlighting service gaps, the platform helps organizations better understand where resources are lacking and where additional support may be required. This can improve planning, strengthen advocacy efforts, and encourage organizations to work together to address areas of need. Ultimately, the Service Gap Identification Tool helps ensure that community needs are recognized and addressed more effectively.

5.8 Dashboard Functionality for Planning, Funding, and Advocacy

The Community Insights Dashboard provides organizations with access to information that can support planning, funding, and advocacy efforts. The dashboard serves as a centralized location where providers can view trends and information collected through platform activity. This may include commonly discussed challenges, emerging service gaps, collaboration activity, funding opportunities, and areas where organizations are seeking partnerships. Presenting this information in a clear and organized format allows service providers to gain a better understanding of issues affecting the homelessness sector.

The dashboard helps organizations make informed decisions by providing evidence that can support strategic planning and future initiatives. Service providers can use the information to identify priorities, allocate resources more effectively, and strengthen funding applications by demonstrating community needs. The dashboard can also support advocacy

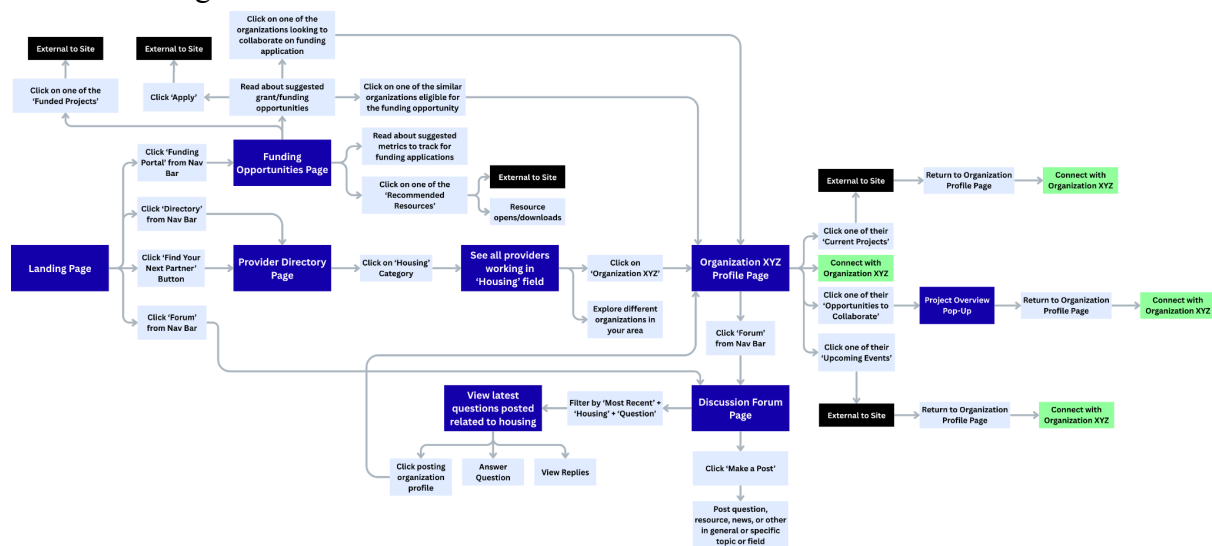
efforts by helping organizations communicate challenges and opportunities using information gathered from across the sector. By bringing important information together in one place, the Community Insights Dashboard promotes informed decision-making and helps organizations work toward shared goals. Ultimately, this feature strengthens the ability of service providers to plan for the future, secure resources, and advocate for meaningful change within the homelessness support system.

5.9 Organization Profiles

The profile structure consists of a social service organization's information, how much funding they have received, the number of available beds, what services they provide, their accessibility, and other details required to categorize the organization. This is based on the current website. Another design idea was proposed that instead showed things about the organization like awards received, funding received, current events, and other efforts.

5.10 Organizational User Journey

Figure 3
User Flow Diagram



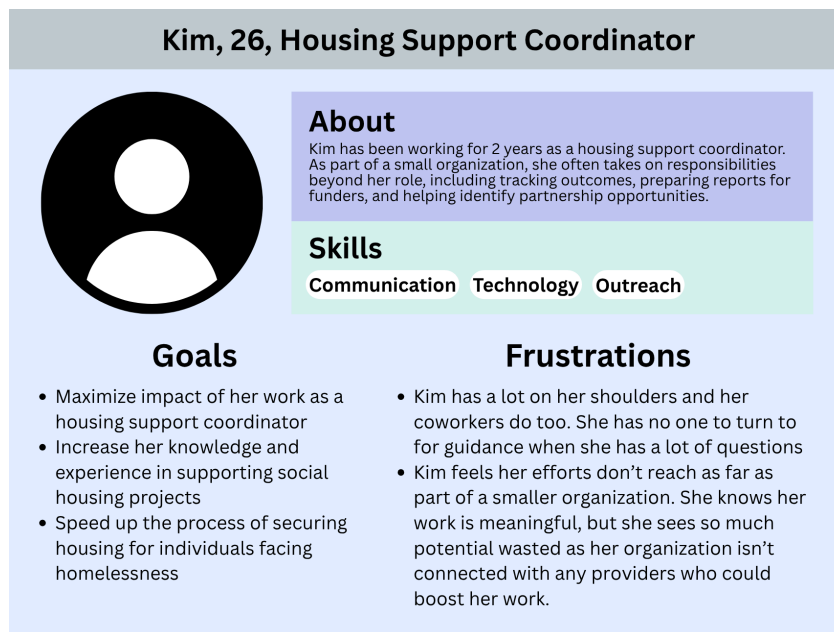
Note. User flow diagram showing journeys user can take on PartnerPath

Canva link: <https://canva.link/ta5tj289c3qaym2>

User Persona

Figure 4

User Persona Card



Note. User persona card for potential user of PartnerPath

User Journey Example (Kim)

➡ I found PartnerPath online while looking for resources for small organizations working in the homelessness support sector. After landing on the homepage, I realize that to use the platform, I need to create an account for my organization. I sign up and fill in some basic information, including where my organization operates, the services we provide, and the populations we support.

➡ Once my account is set up, I am returned to the homepage, now logged in. In the center of the page, I see a button labeled 'Find Your Next Partner'. I click it and am taken to a directory of service providers in my area, organized by category.

➡ I select the 'Housing' category and begin exploring organizations working in housing across my region. One organization catches my attention because I have heard of them before and know they have been successfully supporting housing initiatives for over 20 years. I open their profile and learn more about their work, current projects, and areas of expertise. Seeing an option to 'Connect', similar to LinkedIn, I send them a connection request and continue exploring the platform.

➡ Next, I click on the 'Forum' tab in the navigation bar. I find a discussion forum where users can post questions, resources, and news, and browse previous posts using category and date filters. I post a question under the 'Housing' category asking for guidance on tracking program outcomes and preparing reports for funding applications.

➡ I then navigate to the ‘Funding Portal’. The first thing that catches my attention is a section highlighting suggested metrics that organizations similar to mine are tracking. I also notice several recommended resources, including a grant-writing checklist and a reporting template. Both resources seem highly relevant to my work, so I save them and print copies for future reference.

➡ Having connected with an experienced housing organization, posted a question to the community, and found practical resources to support funding applications, I log off and wait for responses to my connection request and forum post.

5.11 Implementation Roadmap

In implementing the transition of the partnerPath prototype to full operational mode, the project adopts a three-phased implementation roadmap which takes into account our practical constraints in terms of technology and funds available:

Phase 1: Pilot (Months 1–3): Collaborate with YSB and other housing/social services providers in Ottawa to launch pilot version of the website. Focus is placed on the validation of our database intake, the profile labeling system, and forum usability.

Phase 2: Regional (Months 4-9): Open registration for CBO’s, healthcare professionals, and municipal service systems in Ontario. An active moderation process is introduced at this point to ensure new registrants have been properly validated.

Phase 3: Future rollout (Months 10+): Upgrades to the system structure to fully implement use of the database and move past the use of mock files. Development of mobile/tablet user breakpoints at this stage is necessary to ensure access through frontline devices.

5.12 Project Impact

One of the main hypotheses of the project is that Ontario's problem is associated with severe system fragmentation as opposed to a shortage of programs. This means that the design of the Platform is aimed at ensuring a high impact in terms of improving system interactions and relationships, which will allow for bypassing of additional funding of any other new independent programs or services.

Improving Inter-organizational Interaction and Collaboration

Dissolving Operational Silos: By providing interconnected space for housing facilities, mental healthcare organizations, vocational training programs, and financial aid organizations, PartnerPath helps break down these silos and facilitate better interaction. **Resource Visibility:** With the help of innovations such as a "three-way handshake" approach and continuous updating of their profiles, users can gain better insight into available community resources. In this way, they no longer have to act on partial data.

Automatic Partner Matching: With its advanced matching feature, the platform allows users to find compatible partner organizations based on common regional and demographic goals.

Promotion of Collective Problem-Solving and Sharing of Information

Formalized Collaborative Problem Solving: Through the use of the in-built discussion board, communication moves from unstructured channels to a structured forum that acts as a central repository of knowledge. Service providers are encouraged to raise particular questions about how services can be navigated or clients can be tracked, drawing answers straight out of the experiences of the community.

Collaboration Without Pressure: Given that the directory provides a separate platform for communication between providers, organizations can share concerns about operations without feeling any pressure to hide any weaknesses that could make them less appealing to possible funders and policy makers.

Utilization of Sector Funds and Administration

Fund Seeking Made Easier: In a bid to minimize any information gaps, the portal helps bring together rapidly changing grant opportunities on one platform.

Personalized Grant Opportunities: This makes it easier for organizations to find relevant grants because the portal identifies customized grant opportunities according to an organization's profile.

Agency Administration: Agencies gain access to standardized tools such as grant writing checklists and outcome reporting forms.

Continuum Systemic Results

Elimination of Service Holes: Increased cooperation will immediately close the holes in the continuum of care through which vulnerable people often fall.

Avoidance of Duplication: The increased visibility of activities will help avoid duplicate actions performed by various agencies on the same segment of the community.

Resource Optimization: The integration of independent systems will allow local communities to leverage the assets they already have. This is important because in the end, it will lead to better results for people seeking housing stability.

6) Ethics Statement

6.1 Maintaining an "Ethics of Care" Framework

We have purposely embedded this particular project into the framework of an "ethics of care," emphasizing relational interdependence, responsiveness to vulnerability in the world, and dignity over mere usefulness. In the world of homeless services, typical technological solutions often pose ethical problems in that they tend to turn sensitive personal stories into digital records. In order to keep the highly vulnerable persons affected by unstable living conditions from harm, we have made it clear that PartnerPath only collects data on an organizational level without retaining any client information. Our Ethics of Care framework is based off of the ethics board we as a team completed (Appendix D). This deliberate refusal of tracking clients' individual information ensures the security of such vulnerable persons in terms of avoiding surveillance, data theft, and localized threats such as exploitation by criminal gangs.

Moreover, our ethics of care goes one step further to embrace the overstressed and structurally tired frontline workers who are represented in the persona we have created called Kim. Frontline co-ordinators normally face severe burnouts due to the pressures of performing many tasks related to administration and reporting to funding agencies, combined with their sense of profound isolation in the profession. The PartnerPath program acknowledges and celebrates such professionals by creating a platform that is not complicated and creates a community of mutual support.

6.2 Ethical Team Behavior and Project Development

The concept of being ethically engaged involves openness, intellectual honesty, and accountability. During our sprint sprints, the team worked on managing our workload together through task tracking platforms and sync call meetings. However, our biggest ethical challenge came in Sprint 2, where it was apparent through our mid-term presentation and feedback with partners such as the Housing, Infrastructure and Communities Canada (HICC) that our initial solution (Solution One) was too repetitive to the already existing services such as 211 Ontario.

At this crucial moment, our team consciously chose to not take the easy way out by imposing our product into an already saturated industry. Instead, we decided to be accountable to our community partners and to ourselves, and critically evaluate our development. It was evident to all of us that we missed something in our initial research and decided to backtrack in order to align with Solution Two, which gave us the opportunity to design the actual provider collaboration space.

6.3 Manifesting Our Core Values

Our final configuration has been designed to directly manifest three core team values: collaboration, reliability, and service optimization. Regarding our value of collaboration it was represented in our forum-based collaboration tool on the website meant to encourage service providers to directly contact each-other. Through encouraging the exchange of information we aim to take the service providers out of their silo of information and towards a more collaborative experience of knowledge sharing. To help ensure reliability within the hub we made it necessary that all organizations must register before being able to access the entire scope of the platform's functionality. We ensured service optimization through trying to foster communication and community infrastructure rather than creating new programs.

6.4 DEI Perspective on Digital Space

To make sure that our digital space does not unintentionally perpetuate any of the disparities of the past, we used DEI perspective when designing the platform itself as well as considering its overall logic:

DEI Alignments in Platform Design

Conventionally, grassroots organizations and CBOs tend to take a back seat to bigger and highly funded organizations. PartnerPath promotes equality through a layout structure that gives equal importance to all the registered organizations. Through its automated recommendation tool, PartnerPath makes sure to send the grant information that is relevant to the smaller organizations through its automated recommendation tool.

Considering the varying levels of digital literacy skills amongst diverse CBOs, the platform user interface is designed in such a way that it meets usability standards without fail. The combination of simple language with visual aids like light-blue-colored buttons for action points makes it easier for the users to navigate. With regards to aesthetics, the platform structure considers accessibility for those who have impaired vision through a system design that meets WCAG standards for color contrast ratios and high-visibility fonts. This ensures that visually impaired users can comfortably navigate the system from any monitor.

7) Connection to the SDG Goals

7.1 SDG Evaluation Summary

PartnerPath provides support for the objectives of SDGs 17 (Partnerships for the Goals) and SDG 16 (Peace, Justice, and Strong Institutions) by creating channels of communication and cooperation between the different institutions that compose the fragmented network of Ontario's social service system. Through improving cooperation between the different institutions, PartnerPath indirectly has the effect of having positive impacts on the SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), and SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) goals.

7.2 Reflection on Impact Assessment

The final product resulted in the creation of an effective layout design which showcases the role technology plays in effectively integrating different systems (social services, housing services, healthcare). Due to a lack of time as well as a lack of experience in expanding the reach of a web platform, we were not able to carry out a lifecycle analysis of the emissions produced when hosting data [cite: 1] and were also unable to make concrete economic commitments from the funders of the system

7.3 Adjustments for Greater SDG Benefits in the Project

In order to ensure the greatest benefit to future sustainable development through the project, systematic adjustments could be made to the platform to include: Cultural and Multilingual Adaptation and Analysis of the Platform Life Cycle. This involves incorporating language selection features and considerations of cultural competence in our network hub as well as utilising a green cloud-based server that emits zero carbon during digital processes.

8) Process of Completion

8.1 Process of Completion

Based on our given approach being the systemic reasons that affect homelessness our team discovered that fragmentation in service providers worsens the support homeless individuals receive and we created two solutions that could help remedy this gap in care. The first was centred on creating a directory for homeless individuals that would provide them with the summary of all the support programs they could access in one place and the second was a service provider hub that would allow them to connect with and communicate with other service providers and possibly share information with them. These solutions addressed different aspects of the fragmentation of service providers but during our partner presentations on our second week we became informed that there are existing directories like our proposed first solution, such as 211, and that the solution we had decided to go with, even creating a website to demonstrate what that solution would look like, already exists and we would merely be duplicating an existing solution over remedying another identified gap.

After this our team switched over to using our second solution as during partner visits we were told frequently that the lack of communication with other service providers was an issue as it not only weakened the support one organization can provide, but it made coming up with future projects difficult. If service providers shared information and worked together it would create programs of care that can address multiple issues homeless individuals face that cannot be addressed by merely one service provider due to the burden of resources they would have to take on, and it would also lessen the unneeded duplication of support resources. Because of this, and the excited feedback we received about our service provider hub that showed it was a solution that did not currently exist and would be appreciated by each and every partner we decided to go with our second solution. Once we did, we remedied our website to reflect a website focused on service providers and when we showed this solution to partners it received nothing but unilateral praise, it addressed that one aspect of fragmented systems perfectly by creating a resource that would work around that existing gap in communication resulting from services existing in silos. After the delightful feedback we received our team has resolved to further develop the website to reflect concerns, such as data sharing or hosting, and how to promote our project/website and further develop a prototype that can reflect the needs of service providers.

8.2 Team Contributions

Tasks we've done after the Midway Report - required to be filled in by each individual team member.

Muazzan	Theodora	Saad	Hasan	Emma	Olivia	Namdar
Completed Tasks						
	*Present 1 Minute Update *Present to Partners during visit *Answered questions from our partners and gathered useful data (by asking questions) for our research *Directed the refinement of our solution *Completed a Gap Analysis toward our new solution direction *Researched organizations doing similar work to complete a gap analysis to our solution *Created the Source Tracker (with annotations) for the Final Paper *Created the Reference List (on going) for the Final Paper *Co-Designed the Poster for Capstone Day (Olivia) *Collaborated on the group name, Tag Line, and	worked on 4.1-4.4 of final report, software support on GitHub through using copilot and chatgpt for generating listings.json and fixing some errors, also for deploy.yml for viewing online. Also transcribed some of the visitors questions and comments from the demo day	designed and built the website using AI tools to work faster. This helped him quickly test ideas and create a simple, user-friendly site. Completed 3.4, 4.2, 4.3, 4.4, 4.5 of this report.	Helped research design elements to be adapted for the Website Presented to Partners about our Second Solution informing them why we went with the decision we did Prepared an outline for team on how we want to approach a Funding Database on our Website Brainstormed direction for Project, helped narrow in how we can help service providers Drafted and will complete a capstone day pamphlet with feedback from team. Presented on demo-day and helped answer partner	*Prepared presentation on UX design principles + presented to team *Prepared potential user flow for Solution 1 + presented to team *Ideated features for solution 2 after shift and proposed them in team meeting *Presented project development to partners on meeting days *Developed mockups in Canva for every page of project platform and presented to team - with refinement based feedback from teammates *Drafted and will complete capstone day poster - with feedback from teammates *Worked on demo day elevator pitch *Presented on demo day + answered questions *Updated sprint board and assigned tasks - daily *Created user persona for potential PartnerPath user	Pamphlet informations, Script for demo video/ cap stone day video, 4.5 Resource Sharing Hub (1.5) Describe resource-sharing and collaboration features 4.6 Referral Network (2) Explain referral pathways and collaboration workflows 4.7 Partnership Mapping (1.5) Describe partnership development and collaboration opportunities 4.8 Service Gap Identification Tool (1.5) 4.9 Community Insights Dashboard (2)

	Mission Statement *Lead team in collaboration and focused on task at hand - encouraging involvement and asking for idea *Actively participated in updating the sprint board *Communicated in group chat on tasks and the completion of tasks *Assign group member to final paper *Provided suggestions and feed back on site pages (completed by Olivia) *Complete my section of the final paper *Monitor due dates and time and follow up if not completed			questions as certain members weren't available to present Collaborated on the Sprint Board and Team Sessions Finalize Final Report Edit Final Report	*Developed user flow diagram for PartnerPath platform *Developed semi-responsive frontend demo for the purpose of presenting at Capstone day - GitHub and Live site linked in report. *Completed my sections of final report	Describe dashboard functionality for planning, funding, and advocacy Explain service gap reporting and needs assessment features Presented on demo day.
Current Tasks						
	*Finalize Poster *Finalize Pamphlet for Capstone Day			Finalize Pamphlet	*Finalize Capstone day poster *Finalize Pamphlet for Capstone Day	video
Future Tasks						

[Link to the Task Document](#) for everything before the midway the start of the second week and the delegation of parts for the Final Report.

8.3 Sprint Summary

Sprint 1 - Monday, June 8 to Tuesday, June 9

Sprint 1 consisted of efforts towards developing solution 1 from our two solutions ideated. Research on user experience principles and development of potential user flows laid grounds for development. We hoped to have some benchmark examples of platforms that had similar functions, but nothing requested was documented. Some potential features were proposed and we had hopes of pursuing this solution. One teammate researched policies around data that would have been very useful to consider if we pursued solution 1. The goal of this sprint was to solidify a base for our project, but with incompleting tasks, we did not start in a very good place.

Sprint 2 - Tuesday, June 9 to Wednesday, June 10

Tuesday, we presented to some of our partners for feedback. HICC brought very valuable feedback and questioned the need for our solution 1 when platforms like 211 Ontario or 511 central intake in Toronto exist. We felt very shocked that these had not been brought up or found sooner and taken on as direct competition to what our solution was supposed to do. We decided to shift to solution 2, the provider collaboration hub. There was a lot of disconnect amongst team members as the description and goal of our new solutions needed to be reiterated many times. A task in this sprint for EVERYONE was to read the description of solution 2 from our midway report. This task was evidently not completed by the entire team when we met Wednesday morning. Outcome: more time spent explaining the solution we had already come up with, presented on, and had in our report. Wednesday at the end of day, if people still didn't understand, then they were just completely checked out.

Sprint 3 - Wednesday, June 10 to Thursday, June 11

Progress was made on the poster and pamphlet, with the name and logo of our platform being decided during late night meetings and on zoom call in the morning. Theodora prepared very beneficial and well done work with a gap analysis showing what's out there that achieves some of what our solution will and where we fill the gap they are missing/do it better, a source tracker for all research performed, and final paper task tracker. The tracker allowed us to assign tasks for the final report on Thursday. Also on Thursday, in this sprint, we had some development on our coded website and a mockup of what the website could ideally look like beyond functionality - more user-friendly and easy to navigate. A script was prepared for demo day and was iterated upon to keep it more straight to the point and not a step by step guide. Outcome of this sprint: a path forward to demo day with what we would present and what we would say.

Sprint 4 - Thursday, June 11 to Friday, June 12

This sprint featured some final report work to be completed, and some additional preparatory work for demo day such as finalizing our elevator pitch. A new way of showing our website was prepared that fulfilled more of the UX design principles presented at the start of the week. Both the coded, in-progress, website and page mockups were presented to gain feedback on both. The pamphlet draft was finalized with cohesion of fonts across our materials and was printed for guests who came to our presentations. Outcome: a demo day presentation that could garner proper feedback from partners and guests.

Overall reflections

Throughout all of these sprints, we really struggled with communicating progress updates, asking questions, getting feedback, etc. Instructions for tasks were relatively straight forward, yet they were not followed, nor clarified by the individuals assigned to them. It was difficult to assign tasks when people were not present, or if they were, they did not offer to do anything specific that might be easier for them with their skillsets. We felt managers could have helped with holding people accountable to their tasks and doing them correctly, but they did not. We struggled to update the sprint board individually, so we resorted to updating it on call with one person moving tasks to the ‘completed’ sections.

8.4 Project Management

Despite efforts presented through our Team's Charter outlining what effective team communication would look like, such as providing consistent daily check-ins during the evening to update the rest of team about the progress of your work, as-well as finishing work by 11pm, these guidelines were ultimately not followed through on. Across the two weeks there were consistent issues of providing clear updates to work done that made it difficult for everyone to keep track of the progression of certain tasks as-well as what other members were working on. Thus, during a lot of in-class time that were designed to be times of effective brainstorm and working together to progress on the project, a lot of these sessions were taken up partly by what would be described as catch-up sessions, where people presented what work they had done only during these sessions rather than within our dedicated group-chat. While this was a form of communication it made slowed down the entire process of working on the project because much of the work needed for the project was interconnected; we could not begin designing a pamphlet or poster explaining our solution if our team did not have equal access to the website or lacked proper updates on the progress of the website. Thus, we had a lot of situations where during these team sessions we had to explain the reasons why work was completed in a certain way and even had examples of where work had to be re-done entirely because it did not match our current solution which meant we had wasted valuable time that could've been saved through providing proper updates.

Thus, our team could have worked effectively if everyone not only attended the meetings in person in order to properly brainstorm as there was an issue of people online, outside of our Ottawa team members, rarely speaking up unless prompted that meant much of our discussion time was taken up usually only by the same people; attending in person, especially during the second week, could have changed this. And while our team was lucky to have multiple computer science majors to help with coding, during our second week we faced a roadblock where the website created by these people did not accurately reflect what was discussed during our team sessions which was likely because not everyone attended the meetings in person, but also did not communicate the work they were doing. Had we waited to design an outline for the website by team members with backgrounds in design then it would've been the proper template that those with the computer science backgrounds to work off and create a project that not only looks how we would like it to from a design standpoint, but also reflect the exact services we wanted to provide with our website. For example, the first website focused more on providing a service similar to 211 which we had decided against after being informed our first Solution was essentially what 211 offered and we would find better success bridging the service provider gap. Had our team all attended the meeting and spoken equally during the day we were presented with that knowledge, or even be given a design template mockup in Canva before working on the website, then that roadblock would have never existed.

Overall while some members worked together there was a lack of proper communication from most of the group, as well as unequal effort put into the work that made the project difficult to even create and resulted in an overall frustrating experience for everyone.

9) Interdisciplinary Reflection

From the onset, our team believed that we would greatly benefit from having a multi-disciplinary team as we come from diverse backgrounds of education such as Environmental Science Management, Computer Science, Psychology and Multidisciplinary Design which would allow us to examine our project from varying lenses that only one perspective would fail to accurately capture. And while having Computer Science members, for example, did cover issues that could not be addressed by other members and their respective backgrounds such as being able to code and create a working directory or website, there was far less involvement of various approaches than we initially believed. While perspectives like Environmental Science Management were greatly helpful in creating guidelines for our project, such as how our team would function as a group, and managing who was responsible for what based on Theodoradora's work experience in management type roles, the follow through was quite lacking.

Theodora was the main background to creating our project solution as from her own experience in her discipline she learnt about the existing fragmentation of social services that prevent existing services from operating ideally, backed by research conducted from Emma's experience in the Psychology discipline as she had ample experience in discovering evidence that would explain it is an issue needing to be addressed as that is the backbone of Psychology as a role. Thus our solution only came to be because of the unique disciplinary approaches within our group.

On-top of this our project greatly benefited from the insights of Olivia's background in Multidisciplinary Design who helped create a personalized and clear template or design for our various solutions, illustrating how they would work and also how they would appear in a visual format that allowed our group to hone in on what services we would want to provide in our proposed connection hub and how to expand on the visuals Olivia created for us. Without the Multidisciplinary Design approach the website for our project could not have existed as it was built off the templates provided from the background. So, overall, our project made great use of the various insights not covered by merely one discipline which also served as a personal example of why collaboration across disciplines is necessary for creating effective work; a fitting analogy for the proposed solution of creating a hub where various service providers would share information and collaborate from despite existing in different sectors.

And yet, despite the clear benefits that we experienced from looking at our project through the lens of various disciplines and how that informed the end project we have created and are developing further, there were numerous hurdles that affected the overall synthesis of our project. As a whole I would say that the project we presented during Demo-Day was not a complete synthesis of our disciplinary approaches and insights despite efforts to make the collaborative hub a synthesis of the solution to help address fragmentation that was informed by varying disciplines.

The biggest issue we faced when working towards synthesis is there was an overall lack of communication both outside of class and within the class. Given that our project was centred upon the idea of creating a hub which various service providers would update their information and use as a means to connect with other service providers it would be a project that individuals with a computer science background would be working together to complete, yet throughout our meeting most of them either did not speak up or attend, leaving the website to mainly be designed by only one person, rather than three. Due to this our project direction suffered as because those individuals did not speak during these meetings they also rarely knew about what solution we were going with for our project and thus after we decided in our meeting on Tuesday we were switching focus to Solution because individuals were not present in the meeting or rarely contributed to do the discussions they created a website geared towards Solution 1. This wasted a lot of the time we could have used on furthering our project or further developing the hub we made as we had to inform the rest of the team that we were not going with Solution 1 and they had to change the website that they made; if our team had contributed equally during the discussions then they would have understood our direction and develop the website more effectively.

This lack of equal contribution made it so our synthesised project did not reflect what was discussed. That challenge was one consistent throughout our entire project timeline despite efforts made to encourage team-mates to contribute equally within discussions and use their disciplinary background in our discussions to explain how they believe the project should look like and how they would design a project based on how difficult it would be to develop then it would've reflected within our hub. If they considered the design approaches developed by Olivia as-well as review the research we conducted, and research actual website designs that reflect a service provider hub, then the final synthesis of all our ideas within the website developed would have accurately reflected everything talked about rather than being based on only the idea they considered to go with an individual.

Ultimately because there was a lack of communication from those with the Computer Science discipline than they did not communicate what design they were going with nor how they were implementing everything we discussed as a team, then it resulted in a website that reflected the base idea we going with, did not accurately showcase the solution we developed to address the fragmentation between service providers. Members had conducted research both through going to the partner sites but also researching existing information on the gaps in communication between service providers yet because various team-members did not look over at the research conducted then it slowed down our entire process.

We had asked people who were responsible for designing the website to research existing websites or directories to not only compare our idea with, such as seeing if either of our solutions had been created by other organizations or to create a gap analysis with existing websites to discover ways our project could fix gaps in fragmentation even if the overall project was similar to existing databases. Yet, the people responsible for creating the website did not do either of these tasks, nor consult the individuals who had partly researched the existing databases, resources or websites that should have been done by the individuals

coding and creating those websites themselves then they created an overall project that failed to address the gaps we were looking to solve.

Yet, despite these challenges faced by the group there was some synthesis that was effectively received which was represented in the design approaches that Olivia conducted. Olivia used her multi-disciplinary design background to create a template that reflected the solution we wanted to go with, she created multiple designs that sufficiently addressed the fragmentation gap we were concerned with that was discovered by the research done by other members, and the gap analysis conducted by Theodora. The design that Olivia created was positively received by the partners and the various groups that visited our table at the demo-day which demonstrates a clear synthesis of various discipline approaches and the benefits of the various discipline approaches as Olivia only created the design ideas she did based on efforts conducted by other members who had experience with research. And the website made by Hasan did reflect the Solution we came up with during our group discussions. So while there wasn't clear communication at every point, the project we created did reflect our team discussions and the solution we came up with as a group. The website was a combined effort of various members of the team, namely those in Computer Science and its features reflected a way to bridge the gap service providers needed.

10) Professional Project Video

<https://drive.google.com/drive/u/3/folders/1SpX6FZRQhJRmFysAI-V6slx-BCYmC2PL>

Reference List

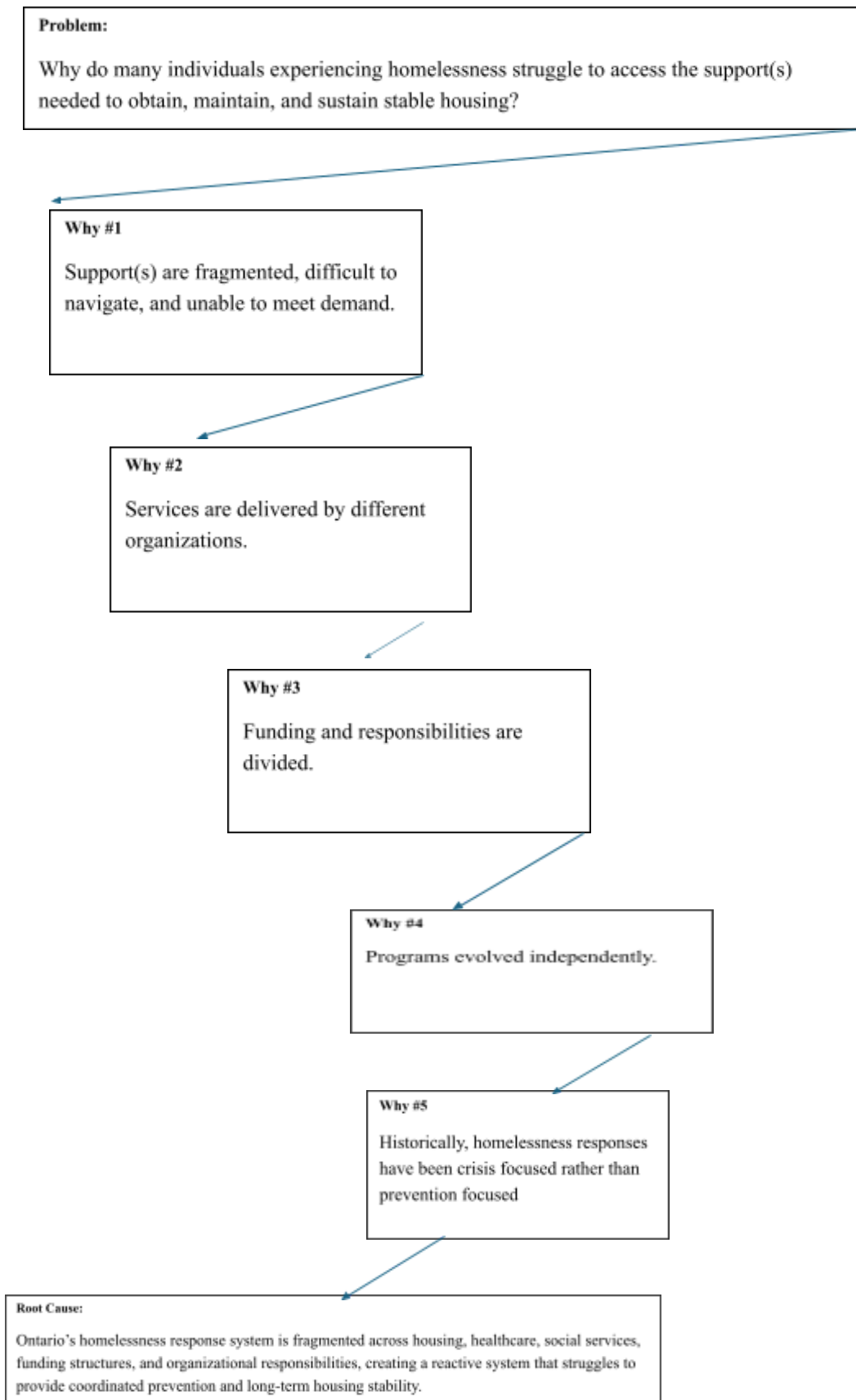
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11) Appendix

Appendix A

5 Why Analysis

Systems Approach to Homelessness



Appendix B

Service Support Gap Analysis – Ontario Homeless Sector

Existing systems support service navigation, client data management, funding awareness, research, advocacy, and sector leadership separately. However, there remains a gap for a provider-focused collaboration and coordination platform that helps organizations identify partners, share lessons learned, discover funding opportunities, identify service gaps, and strengthen collaboration across the homelessness-support ecosystem. Rather than replacing existing services, the proposed solution complements them by improving communication, collaboration, and coordination among organizations already working to prevent and reduce impact to those experiencing homelessness and those aiming to exiting homelessness.

Category	Existing System	What It Does	Overlap With Our Idea	Gap Our Project Could Fill
Service Navigation	211 Ontario	Public-facing directory and data dashboard for community and social services.	Service directory and community needs information.	Provider collaboration, partnership development, funding awareness, organizational challenges, lessons learned, and service-provider networking.
Client Data & Case Management	HIFIS	Client-level homelessness data system supporting coordinated access and case management.	Provider coordination and client-service data.	Provider collaboration hub focused on partnerships, grants, shared learning, and sector improvement rather than client records.
Client Data & Case Management	Community Information Exchange (CIE)	Cross-sector coordination and referrals between organizations.	Provider coordination and information sharing.	Collaboration focused on organizational partnerships, service gaps, funding opportunities, and lessons learned without requiring client-level data sharing.
Sector Coordination & Planning	Alliance to End Homelessness Ottawa	Community planning, sector coordination, and advocacy.	Sector-wide coordination efforts.	Live collaboration platform where providers can identify partners, discuss operational challenges, share resources, and build projects together.
Funding & Grants	ONPHA Funding Tracker	Tracks affordable housing and homelessness funding opportunities.	Funding visibility.	Integration of funding opportunities with provider networking, collaboration, and partnership development.
Funding & Grants	Ontario Trillium Foundation	Provides grant opportunities and community funding programs.	Grant awareness.	Homelessness-specific collaboration, partnership matching, and shared learning tied directly to funding opportunities.
Research & Knowledge Sharing	Homeless Hub	Research, training resources, evidence summaries, and sector knowledge mobilization.	Knowledge sharing and best practices.	Real-time operational collaboration, local partnership development, and service-provider networking.
Advocacy & Sector Leadership	Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness (CAEH)	National leadership, advocacy, Housing First promotion, and systems-change initiatives.	Sector coordination and best-practice development.	Day-to-day provider collaboration, service-gap identification, partnership building, and operational coordination.
Advocacy & Sector Leadership	Canadian Housing and Renewal Association (CHRA)	National housing-sector advocacy, networking, and representation.	Sector networking and knowledge exchange.	Local homelessness-provider collaboration, operational coordination, and cross-sector partnership development.

Appendix C

Source Tracker

This source tracker connects each transition gap our group has identified with supporting evidence from Canadian homelessness literature and policy resources. These sources support our solution(s) that are aimed at improving coordination and access to existing support(s) can strengthen homelessness response and exiting homelessness.

Source Tracker for Final Paper

Existing System	Purpose / Function	How It Informed the Gap Analysis	Annotation	APA 7 Reference
211 Ontario	Public-facing directory of community and social services across Ontario.	Demonstrates that a centralized service directory already exists.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows us that Ontario already has a well-established service navigation system. Therefore, this concludes that our solution should focus on improving provider collaboration rather than duplicating service directories.	211 Ontario. (n.d.). 211 Ontario. https://211ontario.ca
HIFIS	National client-level homelessness data management and coordinated access system.	Demonstrates that client information and case management systems already exist.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows us how homelessness data is currently collected and shared among service providers. It supports our proposed solution is not intended to replace client-level case management systems.	Employment and Social Development Canada. (2024). Homeless Individuals and Families Information System (HIFIS). https://www.canada.ca/en/employment-social-development/programs/homelessness/hifis.html
Community Information Exchange (CIE)	Cross-sector information sharing and referral coordination among service providers.	Demonstrates existing referral and information-sharing capabilities.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows us how organizations can coordinate referrals and share information. This helps our team to identify the remaining gaps that are related to partnership development, organizational learning, and service-provider networking.	Ontario Health. (n.d.). Community Information Exchange. https://www.ontariohealth.ca
Alliance to End Homelessness Ottawa	Community planning, advocacy, and sector coordination.	Demonstrates existing coordination efforts within the homelessness sector.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows the current efforts to coordinate homelessness responses at the community level. It supports our solution for a stronger operational collaboration and ongoing communication between frontline organizations.	Alliance to End Homelessness Ottawa. (n.d.). About us. https://www.endhomelessnessottawa.ca
ONPHA Funding Tracker	Tracks housing and homelessness funding opportunities.	Demonstrates that funding information already exists.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows that organizations can already access information about funding opportunities. It supports the opportunity to improve awareness and collaboration around funding applications and partnership development.	Ontario Non-Profit Housing Association. (n.d.). Funding opportunities. https://onpha.on.ca

Ontario Trillium Foundation	Provides grants and funding opportunities for community organizations.	Demonstrates the availability of community funding.	(Gap Assessment) This source shows us that funding programs are available to support community initiatives. It reinforces to our group the value of connecting providers with both funding information and collaborative opportunities.	Ontario Trillium Foundation. (n.d.). Granting. https://otf.ca
Homeless Hub	National research, training, and knowledge mobilization platform focused on homelessness.	Demonstrates that evidence and best-practice resources already exist.	(Gap Assessment) This source provides access to research, evidence, and educational resources related to homelessness. It supports our finding that the information exists, but operational collaboration between organizations remains fragmented.	Homeless Hub. (n.d.). About Homeless Hub. https://www.homelesshub.ca
Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness (CAEH)	National advocacy organization promoting systems change and Housing First approaches.	Demonstrates leadership and coordination at the national level.	(Gap Assessment) This source tells us that national efforts to advance homelessness policy and systems change. It helps us to see the different strategic advocacy activities from local operational coordination among service providers.	Canadian Alliance to End Homelessness. (n.d.). About us. https://caeh.ca
Canadian Housing and Renewal Association (CHRA)	National housing-sector advocacy, networking, and representation organization.	Demonstrates existing networking and sector leadership functions.	(Gap Assessment) This source illustrates how housing organizations collaborate and advocate at the national level. It supports our finding that a gap in local provider collaboration and cross-sector operational coordination exists.	Canadian Housing and Renewal Association. (n.d.). About CHRA. https://chra-achru.ca

Appendix D Ethics Board

https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVHNAcLgI=?share_link_id=699844394511

Link to our completed Ethics Board

Appendix E

Website Github

Link to the site that stores the files for our team's website
[GitHub.com/lalogongum/C4_project](https://github.com/lalogongum/C4_project)

Appendix F
Page Mockups Canva File

Link to Canva file containing platform page mockups: <https://canva.link/3w5dpsi6uavhxml>

Appendix G

Site Visit Notes

Notes from visit to Women's Youth Shelter & Youth Services Bureau - Downtown Ottawa:

- Big disconnect between institutions and the actual problem of homelessness
- Levels: government, policy, intermediary services, front line workers, people experiencing homelessness
- There is an information gap between and within the levels
- There is no organizing group that intermediary service providers are under
- Disconnect amongst intermediaries and between them and the front line - they don't know each other exist, thus are not working together - which would be much more effective
- Federal gov has direct connections with municipalities for building social housing - could be a way for service providers to get through to policy makers?
- Data: there are not enough data requirements to provide to funders - orgs don't know what to collect and present - not clear what is needed to get funding
- Disconnect between policy makers and funders
- Service providers face the negative impacts of this

Appendix H

Feedback from Presentations - Friday, June 5

Trek for teens feedback

Solution 1

different formats of resources

Solution 2

directly targets gap between service providers

Question: what kpis generate necessary data to drive funding?

- number of how many people accessing services
- focus on general data - get the big picture - not personal data (demographics)
- gaps between service providers
- oversight not encompassing all aspects of services that need to be provided
- gap btwn providers and funders is biggest area that needs addressing

BetterStreet feedback

- both services are useful

solution 1

- 511 central intake
- outreach worker helps
- barriers to even arrive at a shelter
- handout would need to be updated very often - but would be helpful
- alternative to central intake - supports gets to you based on what you need - like 911 services what do you need
- what is a redesigned version of central intake - how to function - how to approach - what would it look like

Mike YSB feedback

- Ottawa organizations are already striving towards this

He mentioned:

Structure for referrals right now is: common consent for referrals in municipalities - cities and agencies agree
privacy protection - how do we do protect health info financial info - consent for everything - and obey the laws

COB - portable housing benefit - better than fed gov.

fed funds municipalities with housing allowance - can only be used within municipality

- not dictated by gov where you can live
- COB style could be applied to our solution

- coordination with funding - evolving in ad hoc way - no leadership to guide coordination
multiple agencies looking for same funding - job loss and gain in agencies - combative systems - work together is better

- YSB diversion/shelter and CHO upstream do full continuum of support - dont compete for funding because both are needed

- Agencies could do specific things rather than one doing a bunch of unrelated things
- Consultation is needed for policies rather than just implemented - co-design needed
- providers could be one voice rather than competing which would improve their ability to get things done
- consider where funding comes from and what outcome is - homelessness is municipal responsibility
- consider with mental health or justice - that is provincial , but we are looking at municipalities
- determine goal impact - provincial or scalable and repeatable municipal
- privacy and confidentiality - where people stay - where theyre from or going - be careful with that
- 40-50% of time is spent navigating systems for clients

HICC - Vanessa feedback

Solution 1

- who's responsible for developing and maintaining
- limitations around info sharing and safeguarding

Solution 2

- look at collaborators already existing: CAEH canadian alliance to end homelessness, homelessness hub, CHRA Canadian housing renewal association
- data sharing protections what needs to be protected
- high vis - names but not full info - data cleaned to protect
- critiques exist
- Indigenous data sovereignty - limitations
- who needs to be at the table for delivery and development of this system
- situate in Ontario - navigation btwn municipalities, and federal role there
- Federal gov can pay for someone to get to doctors but cant pay for those services - Canada Health Act
- how do you want to bridge those relationships and commitments - how can you mandate them to come to the table and legal frameworks and responsibilities that exist
- affirm responsibility for partners to show up to these discussions

Appendix I
Link to Project Demo GitHub Repository

Link: <https://github.com/oashton21/partnerpath>